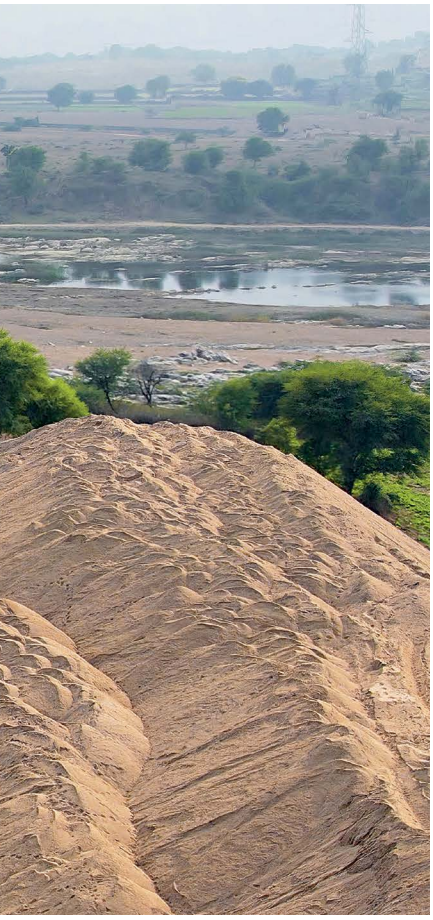


story to the rampant corruption illegal mining has brought into state administrations. The reproof came just months after Rajasthan witnessed an unprecedented #SaveAravalli movement, a sign of how benumbed administrations are even towards the public mood, forget the environment.

Injury to fragile systems like the Chambal may be irreparable. The courts have reiterated a basic scientific principle: sand mining must follow replenishment cycles. Extract from a stretch, leave it untouched for at least five years to allow natural regeneration. On that logic, the Rajasthan High Court had quashed 93 gravel mining leases this year—likely in vain.

There is a workable alternative—one Rajasthan itself has experimented with, albeit without scaling it. The desiltation initiative at the Bisalpur Dam on the Banas river showed extraction can align ecological and economic goals. The idea here was to segregate usable sand from silt, then track its movement through GPS. Multiple ends were served: reservoir capacity is being restored, revenue flows were kept up without pressure on natural riverbeds.

But such systems disrupt entrenched interests that profit from opacity. These are times when states have to be stopped from shrinking sanctuaries and lowering the height of hills to legitimise illegal extraction. ■

Takeaways

- **On Apr. 17, the SC pulled up two states for not reining in "the modern dacoits" of the Chambal, warned it would "deploy CRPF"**
- **Trigger: forest guard killed in Morena, MP, on Apr. 8 by sand smugglers; in January, Dholpur in Rajasthan saw a similar killing**
- **On Apr. 2, the SC quashed a Rajasthan order opening up 732 ha of Chambal sanctuary; flagged hints of official complicity**

ary, forest guard Jitendra Singh Shekhawat tried to stop a speeding tractor-trolley at the Jhiri checkpoint in Dholpur, Rajasthan. The vehicle ran him over.

On April 8, the scene was repeated, in nearby Morena, Madhya Pradesh. Harikesh Gurjar was run over as his patrol team intercepted a tractor-trolley at 6 am. It was at the next hearing, April 17, that Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta warned that if states failed to act against the "modern dacoits", officials would be held personally accountable. The complicity implied there shifts the

▶ GOA

A Missionary and His Maledictor

BJP seeks to atone in Goa after platforming an extreme YouTuber, angering Catholics

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

IT'S UNCLEAR WHETHER IT WAS STRATEGY or just zeal gone out of hand, but this was a controversy the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) could have done without in the lead-up to the assembly election in early 2027. Having a self-ordained saffronista YouTuber trash the patron saint of Goa wouldn't seem the smartest way to make friends with the state's Catholic community, who make up a bulk of the 25 per cent Christian population here and whose blessings the BJP has carefully solicited over the years.

All that threatened to unravel when Gautam Khattar, who describes himself as a "spiritual beat journalist" and runs an outfit called the Sanatan Mahasangh, made derogatory remarks against Saint Francis Xavier at an event in Vasco earlier

ONLINE FIRE Gautam Khattar being escorted to Crime Branch, Goa, Apr. 26

